days'. Tata Tea replied that Gogoi would report as directed on 24 September. He did so and was promptly arrested on the ground of aiding and abetting militant activities in Assam. He was released by the Gauhati High Court on 13 November on conditional bail.

Gogoi's arrest left both Tata Tea and Ratan red-faced. To his detractors, Ratan appeared to have hidden the fact that Gogoi was in India from the state government. The Assam government again took an aggressive stance against the group. Chief Minister Mahanta said that if 'he [Gogoi] was in the Tata guest house, it amounts to suppression of information and harbouring of an offender'.

Jaffa, on his part, alleged that Tata Tea was amongst the list of tea companies aiding the militants. An article in a leading newspaper said that he accused the company of giving militants 'easy money' and that the company had been 'buying peace' instead of seeking official assistance.

The press release that Tata Tea had taken out a month earlier, revealing that it had met the ULFA head on the IB's advice, got the state government fuming. Faced with this revelation, Mahanta mounted an acerbic attack on the IB. In an interview he said: 'I have not been told anything. Tata Tea claims they had IB authorisation. But the IB has no right to authorise anyone to wine and dine extremists. Even the home minister wasn't aware of the ULFA meetings. It seems there is a conspiracy to destabilise the Government … I wouldn't like to say anything now. All tea companies, except the Tatas, assured us cooperation in fighting militancy.'

Ratan's woes kept piling up. While he was battling the state government's allegations, on 4 October 1997, a leading daily published transcripts of illegal taps of certain telephone conversations. These apparently revealed that Nusli Wadia, the chairman of Bombay Dyeing and 'a childhood friend of Tata', headed 'the damage-control effort [in Assam] by trying to use major political connections'.

The tapes purportedly contained conversations between Wadia, industrialist Keshub Mahindra, Rajya Sabha member Jayant Malhoutra, Field Marshal Sam Manekshaw and Ratan regarding Tata Tea's problems with the Assam government. 'The alleged conversations related to supposed efforts to use political influence to pull the company out of the crisis.' The transcripts, according to the newspaper, indicated that the 'Tatas could have withheld damaging evidence from the Assam Police'.